

Health Inequality and Public Policy

(1) Introduction

Monday, 15. September 2025

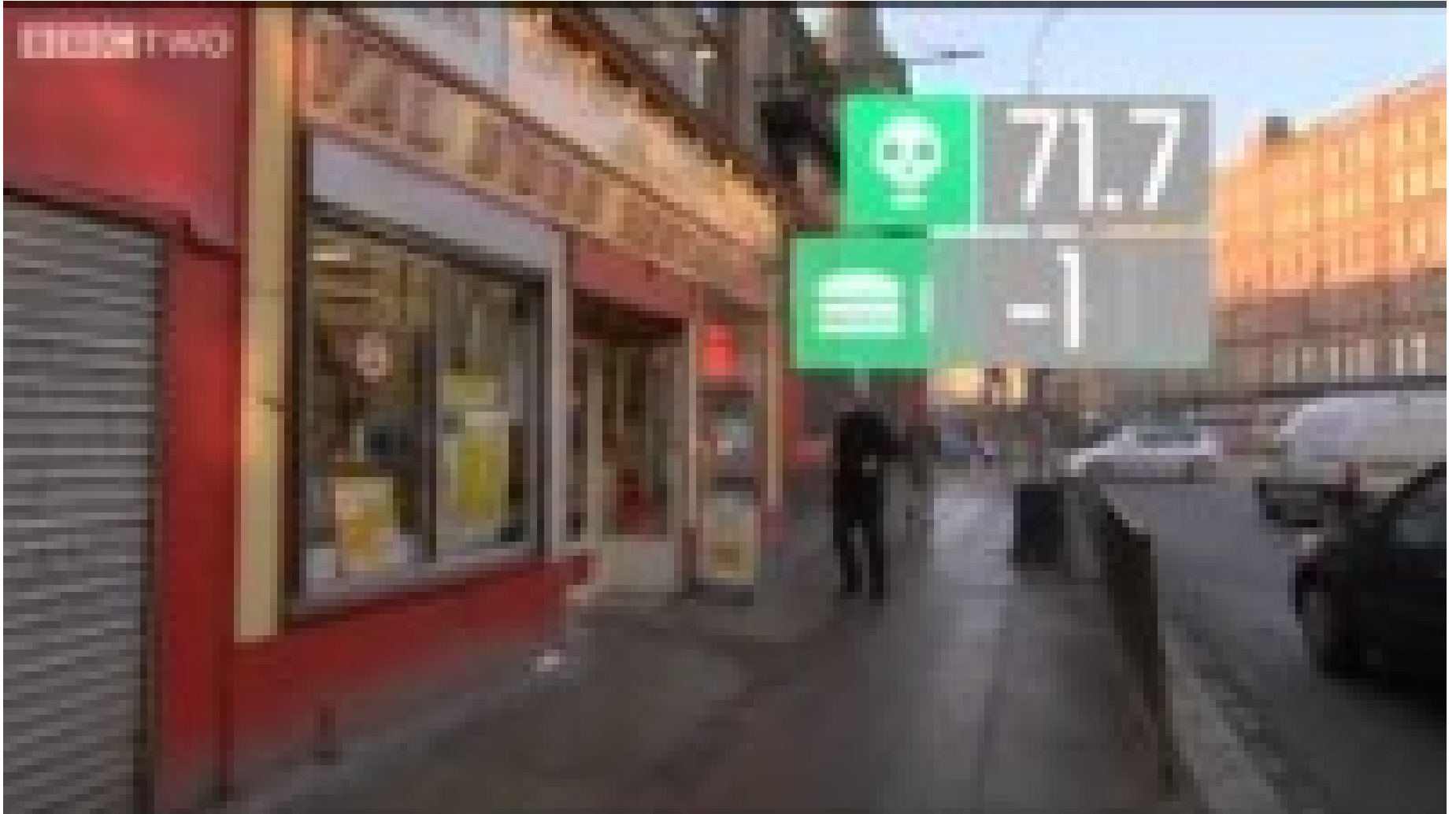
Ass.-Prof. Dr. David Weisstanner
Faculty of Health Sciences and Medicine
University of Lucerne

WHAT DOES OUR TITLE PICTURE SHOW?



WHAT DOES THIS HAVE TO DO WITH HEALTH?

Danny
Dorling,
Professor of
Human
Geography
at the
University of
Oxford



ALSO IN SWITZERLAND?



Westend61 / Getty

Warum Reiche bessere Chancen auf ein gesundes Leben haben

Wir werden immer älter und bleiben im Alter länger gesund. Das gilt
aber nicht für alle. Die gesundheitliche Ungleichheit nimmt zu –
auch in der Schweiz.

Theres Lüthi 03.06.2023, 21.45 Uhr

HEALTH EQUITY

FACTS AND FIGURES FOR SWITZERLAND



 Schweizerische Eidgenossenschaft
Confédération suisse
Confederazione Svizzera
Confederaziun svizra

Swiss Confederation

Federal Department of Home Affairs FDHA
Federal Office of Public Health FOPH

2018

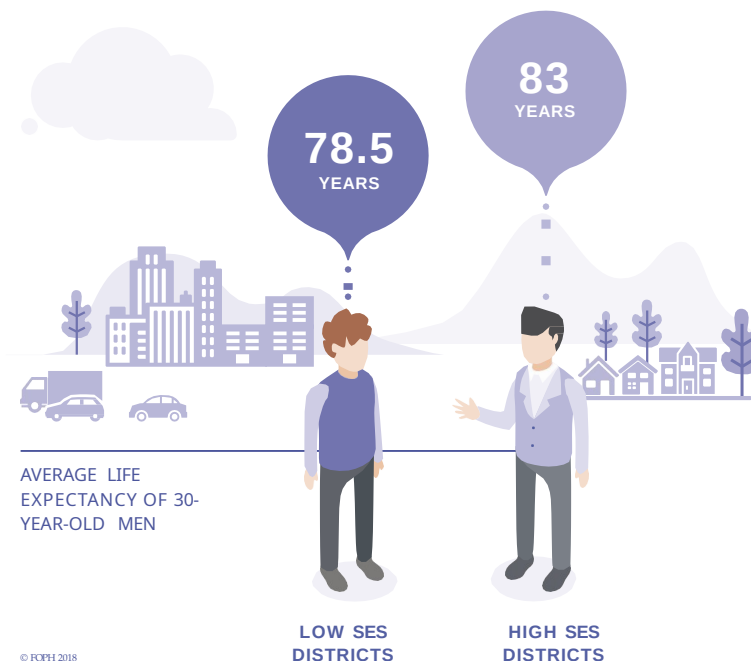
Focus on equality of opportunity



Life expectancy

Life expectancy varies by place of residence

Although life expectancy is high in Switzerland, it can vary significantly. The lower the socioeconomic status (SES) of a commune or district, the lower the life expectancy. For example, between 78 and 83 for 30-year-old men and between 83.5 and 87 for 30-year-old women. In Bern and Lausanne, for example, in districts with a low SES, men die 4.5 years earlier on average and women 2.5 years earlier than in high SES districts.



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WHAT CAN/SHOULD WE DO ABOUT THESE INEQUALITIES?



Sir Michael Marmot
Professor of Epidemiology at
University College London
Director of the UCL Institute of
Health Equity, and Past
President of the World Medical
Association.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0B5bAXtLPo4>

SIX POLICY AREAS TO ADDRESS HEALTH INEQUALITY

1. Give every child the best start in life
2. Education and lifelong learning
3. Employment and working conditions
4. Minimum income necessary for a healthy life
5. Healthy and sustainable places in which to live and work
6. Taking a social determinants approach to prevention

Prof. Marmot: “The evidence shows that we can take action on those”

...but are countries moving in this direction?



Schweizerische Eidgenossenschaft
Confédération suisse
Confederazione Svizzera
Confederaziun svizra

Federal Office of Public Health FOPH

Topics Diseases Insurances Professions Policy & laws Research Services The FOPH

Homepage > Policy & laws > National health policy > Health care topics > Health Equity

Health Equity

Our health system is based on the principle of openness and solidarity. It must be accessible to all, regardless of language, origin, social status or educational level.

Activities to promote health equity

Focus on the socially disadvantaged groups: facts & figures, basic reports and target groups.



Events on Health Equity

Sharing research findings and knowledge on the integration of disadvantaged groups; Health Equity Forum.



Making health promotion accessible to all

Resources for projects, health information and campaigns that take into account the needs of disadvantaged groups.



Strengthening health literacy of disadvantaged groups

The migesplus website, a practical guide to health literacy and other ways of improving knowledge and self-reliance.



Equal opportunities in healthcare

From the federal government's point of view, appropriate healthcare should be available to everyone – regardless of sex, age or sociocultural background.



Healthcare professionals and managing diversity

Recommendations and options for training to improve specialist skills and expertise.



Community Interpreting

When direct communication is difficult, professional community interpreters can step in to help healthcare professionals

Research on Health Equity

Information for specialists looking to devise measures and projects in specific fields.

Programme on Migration and Health 2002-2017

Strategic principles for promoting health equity and for integrating disadvantaged

BAG muss elf Millionen Franken sparen und 20 Stellen streichen

Das Bundesamt kürzt bei der Kinderarzneimittel-Datenbank, bei der Prävention und beim Strahlenschutz.

em, 26. Februar 2025 um 17:07



Das Bundesamt für Gesundheit (BAG) will unter anderem bei der nationalen Datenbank zur Dosierung von Arzneimitteln bei Kindern (SwissPedDose) sparen. | Unsplash

Der Bundesrat und das Parlament haben dem Bundesamt für Gesundheit ein **Sparprogramm verordnet**. Ab 2026 muss das BAG pro Jahr mit elf Millionen Franken weniger auskommen. Nun zeigt die Leitung des Amts, wo sie einsparen will.

«Die Kürzungen tangieren verschiedene Bereiche, mit denen das BAG bis anhin einen wichtigen Beitrag zur Stärkung der öffentlichen Gesundheit leisten konnte», heisst es in einer Mitteilung.

Verzichten will das BAG künftig unter anderem auf folgende Aufgaben:

- Nationale Datenbank zur Dosierung von Arzneimitteln bei Kindern (SwissPedDose)
- Weiterführung des Masterplans Biomedizinische Forschung
- Prävention am Arbeitsplatz
- Prävention in der Gesundheitsversorgung
- **Gesundheitliche Chancengleichheit**

Zu **Reduktionen** kommt es ferner in folgenden Bereichen:

- Strahlenschutz und Chemikalien
- Überprüfung bestehender Leistungen der Kranken- und Unfallversicherung mit dem Health Technology Assessment-Programm

<https://www.medinside.ch/bag-muss-elf-millionen-franken-sparen-und-20-stellen-streichen-20250226>

<https://www.bag.admin.ch/en/health-equity>

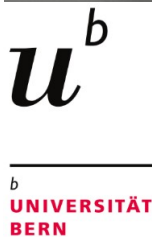
ROUND OF INTRODUCTION

About you:

1. Who are you?
2. Have you come across the topic of health inequality in other courses?
3. What do you expect/wish to learn in this course?



About me:



Teaching:

Health and social policy
Health inequality
Swiss health policy

Research interests:

Comparative health and social policy
Inequality (health, social, economic)
The politicization of health care
Electoral politics

COURSE OBJECTIVES

1. Describe the concept and measurement of health inequality
2. Analyse health inequalities using cross-national survey data (ISSP, ESS)
3. Compare patterns across countries and over time
4. Evaluate how public policies and social contexts shape health inequality
5. Develop an own empirical research project

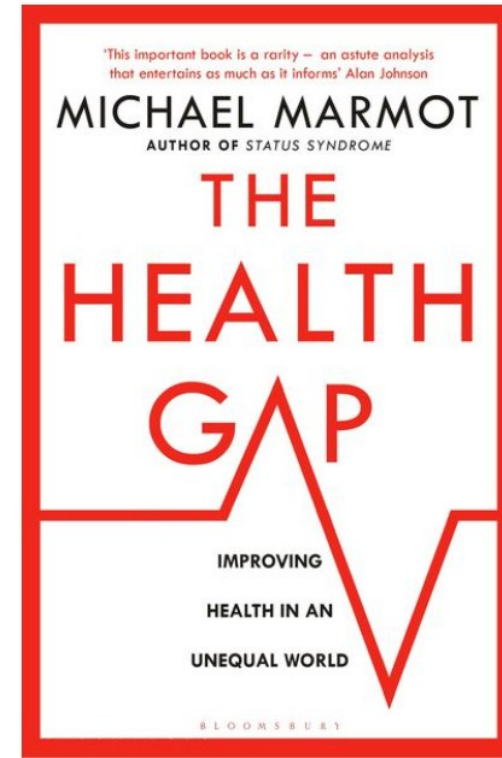
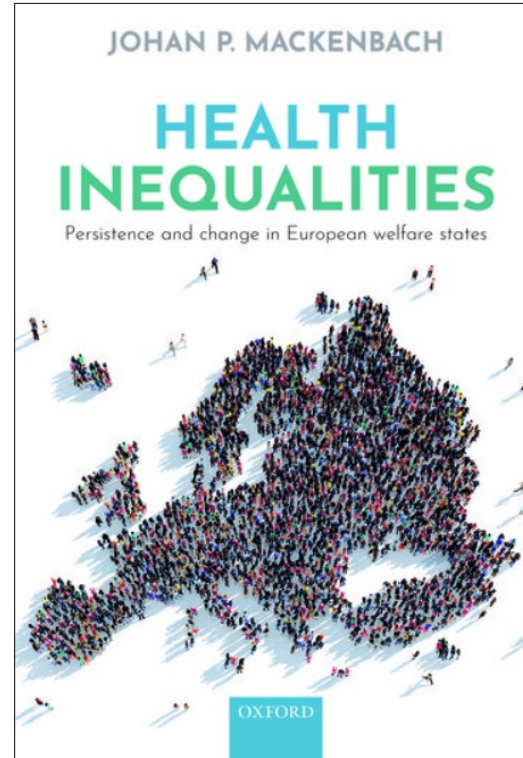
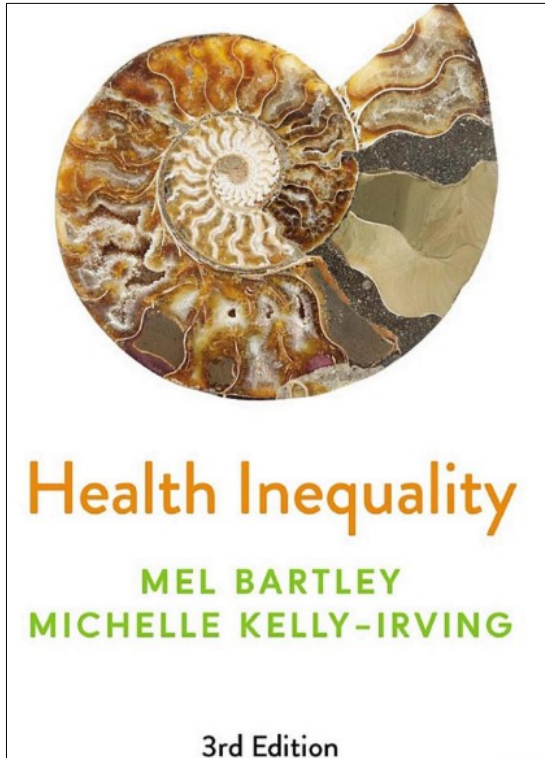
COURSE CONTENTS

Part 1: Introduction; what is health inequality?	today, 22.9.
Part 2: Theories and causes of health inequality	29.9., 6.10.
Part 3: Areas of health inequality (SES, ethnic, spatial, health care)	13.10., 20.10., 27.10., 03.11.
Part 4: When and how to address health inequality	10.11., 17.11.
Part 5: Student presentations and conclusion	24.11., 01.12., 15.12.

Guests:

- Guest talk by Barbara Hosch, Sans-Papiers Zentralschweiz (week 6)
- Author Q&A with Prof. Katherine Smith, University of Strathclyde, Glasgow (week 10)

MATERIALS



+ recent
articles



Voices of Equity

Health equity is a key clinical and public health issue, especially in today's polycrisis world. But what are the current critical challenges and topics in health equity? Who are the populations most affected by health inequities? How can different fields—like social sciences, medicine, and economics—help us better understand and address this issue? This podcast, addressed to equity actors of the healthcare system, healthcare staff, researchers, but also anyone with an interest in this subject, will help you answer those questions. Each episode offers the point of view of an expert in one of the main sub-topics of health equity, in which he or she will respond to 5 key questions. For this podcast, we had the opportunity to meet great personalities known internationally in the field of health equity. "Voices of equity" is a podcast from Unisanté's Department of Vulnerability and Social Medicine. Conception: Patrick Bodenmann, Léa Grosjean and Evelyne Hangartner. Production and distribution: Dounia Künzler, Léa Grosjean, Dan Ribeiro, Christian Cordoba. Hosted on Acast. See acast.com/privacy for more information.

All Episodes



Health inequities through the lens of social determinants of health, with Professor Sir Michael Marmot

Aug 20, 2025

▶ 0:00 / 0:00

For this fourth episode of "Voices of equity", we will explore health inequities through the lens of social determinants of health. Why are the social determinants of health such a crucial topic when addressing health equity? In this time of polycrisis and growing uncertainty, what is the significance of the launch of the WHO's World Report on Social Determinants of Health Equity? We have the honor of addressing these questions with Professor Sir Michael Marmot, a leading figure in the study of health inequalities for over 40 years. He is Professor of Epidemiology at University College London (UCL), Director of the UCL Institute of Health Equity, and former President of the World Medical Association. The discussion was led and hosted by Professor Patrick Bodenmann, holder of the Chair of Medicine for Vulnerable Populations at the University of Lausanne. Hosted on Acast. See acast.com/privacy for more information.



Equity in health systems and policies, with Prof Nancy Krieger

Jun 18, 2025

▶ 0:00 / 0:00

In this third episode, we will discuss what it takes to move toward real equity in health systems and policies, through the lens of an ecosocial approach. What can public health do better to address health equity? And at a time of polycrisis, what are the most urgent levers for change? To explore these questions, we had the great privilege of speaking with Professor Nancy Krieger, world-renowned social epidemiologist at the Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health. We'll also have the chance to hear her views on the current political climate in the United States and its impact on health equity. The conversation was hosted by Mauricio Avendano, quantitative social scientist, Associate Professor at the University of Lausanne and Adjunct Associate Professor at Harvard University. Hosted on Acast. See acast.com/privacy for more information.

<https://open.spotify.com/show/0JyHnF4L5HYzUw52h4VRQu>

COURSE FORMAT

Conceptual part (usually morning, 10:15-11:50)

- Concepts, theories, literature, measurements

Applied part (usually afternoon, 12:30-13:45)

- Using **survey data** to describe, compare, and explain health inequalities across countries & over time
 - International Social Survey Programme (ISSP 2011 & 2021 “Health and Health Care” modules)
 - European Social Survey (ESS Round 7, 2013-14 and Round 11, 2023-24 “Social Inequalities in Health” modules)
- Develop an **own empirical project** using ISSP or ESS data
 - Motivation: practice **core academic skills**
 - Implement an **own empirical research project from A-Z**
 - Apply basic survey research methods, data management, analytical strategies, etc.
 - Practice with the datasets in class, give & receive feedback on your projects
 - Not a methods course – focus on *applying* methods (at any level of methodological sophistication)

ASSESSMENT

Written paper (65%): empirical research paper using ISSP or ESS data

- Individual work: 2500-3000 words
or
group work (2 students): 3500-4000 words
- Preliminary draft due the week before presentation
- Final paper due 29th January 2026, 23:59 CET (delays: -0.5 grade points per day delayed)

Presentation of preliminary findings (25%)

- 24th November or 1st December

Active participation (10%)

- Come prepared to class, having read the mandatory reading, able to summarise its main points, and ready to discuss it with questions or ideas

GETTING STARTED - ISSP

1. Register with GESIS, to be able to download ISSP data: <https://login.gesis.org/>
2. Set up a folder called «DATA»
3. Download the 2011 and 2021 datasets (store in your «DATA» folder):
ISSP 2011:
 - Dataset information: [ISSP 2011 - "Health and Health Care"](#)
 - Download link: https://search.gesis.org/research_data/ZA5800ISSP 2021:
 - Dataset information: [ISSP 2021 - "Health and Health Care II"](#)
 - Download link: https://search.gesis.org/research_data/ZA8000?doi=10.4232/5.ZA8000.1.0.0
4. Open the datasets with your Stata or R, explore the data, make sure it has loaded correctly

GETTING STARTED - ESS

1. Register with the ESS Data Portal (log in with Google account or create a new login): [Logg inn](#)
2. Download the round 7 and round 11 datasets and main questionnaires (store in the DATA folder):
 - ESS round 7 - 2014:
 - Dataset information: [ESS round 7 - 2014. Immigration, Social inequalities in health | ESS - Sikt](#)
 - Download under Datafiles ("ESS7 - integrated file")
 - ESS round 11 - 2023:
 - Dataset information: [The European Social Survey \(ESS\) | ESS - Sikt](#)
 - Download under Datafiles ("ESS11 - integrated file")
3. Open the datasets with your Stata or R, explore the data, make sure it has loaded correctly

OUTLOOK NEXT WEEK

2 22.09.2025 What is health inequality?

Reading: Mackenbach, J. P. (2019). *Health Inequalities. Persistence and Change in European Welfare States*. Oxford University Press. Chapter 2 “Patterns of health inequalities”, pp. 13-47.

Applied focus: First basic descriptive health inequality indicators in the ISSP/ESS

QUESTIONS?



THANK YOU FOR YOUR ATTENTION!

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